pressure, municipal bodies started impounding cows and bulls found straying in public spaces and slapping fines on their owners, leading to the call for a boycott of the BJP by the Maldhari Mahapanchayat ahead of the assembly election. Desai says the Maldharis protested the bill as it penalised them for no fault of theirs. "If the *gauchar* [grazing] land is acquired, where will the cattle go? The cattle rearers must be first systematically rehabilitated with ample grazing land and adequate compensation," he says.

The BJP may have won the election, but it can't afford to alienate the Maldharis further. So, with the HC breathing down its neck, the Bhupendra Patel government instead decided to launch bull castration across the state's eight MCs and 156 municipalities. "Earlier, bulls were used for ploughing the fields and mating cows. Now, as the farmland holding has reduced significantly and the grazing land is scarce, rearing a bull is not economically viable," says agriculture activist Kapil Shah. "Besides, tractors do the bull's job at less cost and time." With one bull able to inseminate up to 30-odd cows in a 60-70-day mating period, and technology-driven options like artificial insemination available to impregnate cows, the utility of bulls is diminished, he explains.

So, what do the farmers do with these bulls? That's exactly the conundrum where the cow vigilante groups are driving the last nail in the coffin. "Earlier, the slaughterhouses would take away the bulls. It was illegal, but an open secret," admits a senior state government official. "Now, due to the fear of cow vigilantes, even that has stopped." Thus, the bulls that were earlier abandoned once they turned old or unserviceable, are now often left to fend for themselves at a much younger age of six months. Looking for food and shelter, they stray onto roads, often attacking pedestrians and vehicle riders.

Dr Falguni Thakar, director of animal husbandry, says the castration drive is in full swing. "We are working in coordination with *panjrapole* (cattle shelter) trusts and farmers. The castration is done in a scientific manner; the method is decided by experts depending on the size and age of bulls," she told INDIA TODAY. Each team consists of a veterinary officer, two livestock inspectors and two handlers. After the castration, the team monitors the bovine's health for a week before moving them to shelters. The drive will continue even after achieving the first benchmark of 50,000, adds Thakar.

Shah says castration is harsh on the psyche of the animal but a solution nonetheless, as a castrated bull (that is, a bullock) is less aggressive and more manageable. But both government officials and industry experts agree it's just a "band-aid solution", which may suffice as a submission in the HC, but is not halfway to the actual solution to the larger problem. Moreover, taking care of the castrated bulls poses a serious problem for the state. "There aren't enough cattle pounds," says Shah. And funding remains another big concern.

According to the animal husbandry department, 105 *panjrapole* shelters, including 17 under the eight MCs, are available to house and take care of the bullocks for their remaining lives. Each of these shelters has a capacity of 100-200 in rural areas and up to 1,000 in urban areas. Even if we highball the combined capacity, it falls short of the 50,000 mark by at least 30 per cent. As for the funds, within a week of the launch of the drive, the CM released Rs 59 lakh assistance to the five charitable trusts that are running these shelters and are beneficiary organisations under the Mukhyamantri Gau Mata Poshan Yojana for the maintenance and upkeep of cow sheds and shelters.

A spirited start to the drive, but a lot will depend on its execution. Not to forget, it was just five months ago that *panjrapole* trusts had brought the traffic in North Gujarat to a halt in late September, after they let over 10,000 cows loose on the highways. Reason: they were irked over the state government's failure to release Rs 500 crore assistance promised under the Gau Mata Poshan scheme in the 2022-23 budget. Back then, the PM had to rush to Gujarat and formally launch the scheme from Ambaji to avoid any further embarrassment to the state's BJP regime ahead of the assembly election. With the HC keeping tabs, the Bhupendra Patel regime is walking a tightrope. Ultimately, though, it's only reimagining urban development and reserving enough grazing land for the livestock that will help the administration take the bull by the horns. ■

THE CATTLE CONUNDRUM

- According to the livestock census released in 2019, Gujarat's cattle population stood at 9.63 million
- Even as the numbers had dropped by 3.5 per cent since 2012, the stray cattle count had surged by 17.5 per cent, from 292,462 to 343,918
- To bring down the numbers and address the related menace, the government is castrating stray bulls, with the first benchmark set at 50,000
- The bovines will then be moved to 105 cow shelters funded under the Mukhyamantri Gau Mata Poshan Yojana
- The CM has so far released Rs 59 lakh assistance to the five charitable trusts that are running these shelters

GUJARAT'S RAPID URBANISATION CAME AT A PRICE FOR ITS TEEMING LIVESTOCK, WHICH LOST BOTH HABITATION AND GRAZING LAND